

STAGE SIX • COMMUNICATION: SPEAKING, READING & WRITING

FIRSTS

DISCUSSION PROMPTS

Open-ended questions to seed group conversation beyond the worksheets

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Discussion Prompts

Stage Six • Communication: Speaking, Reading & Writing

PURPOSE

Individual worksheets answer “what did you write, say, or practice?” These prompts answer a different question: “what's your real, lived experience of communicating, listening, and being heard?” They're open-ended and personal, meant to seed conversation beyond a simple share-out of worksheet answers.

Use these during share-out portions, when a session finishes its planned agenda with time to spare, or when a group's energy needs a genuine, specific prompt rather than “any volunteers?” They're organized by session (matching this stage's six sections), four prompts each.

Given this stage's seventy FIRSTS run across six substantial sessions, these prompts are especially useful as a way to slow down and connect the volume of individual exercises back to something genuinely personal and memorable.

Prompts by Session

SESSION 1

Written Communication

"What's an email you received that genuinely impressed you with how clearly it was written? What made it work?"

"Have you ever sent an email you regretted, tone-wise, after hitting send? What would you change about it now?"

"What's the hardest part of writing for you: getting started, organizing your thoughts, or editing down?"

"Who taught you how to write professionally, if anyone? What's one thing they told you that stuck?"

SESSION 2

Verbal & Presentation Skills

"What's a presentation you've seen that you still remember months or years later? What made it stick?"

"Where does your speaking anxiety actually show up — shaky voice, racing pace, going blank? Has anyone found something that genuinely helps?"

"Have you ever been asked a genuinely surprising question mid-presentation? How did you handle it?"

"What's the difference between a speaker who sounds confident and one who sounds rehearsed?"

SESSION 3

Listening, Reading & Comprehension

"When was the last time you realized, mid-conversation, that you hadn't actually been listening? What pulled your attention away?"

"What's a book or article that genuinely changed how you think about something in your field?"

"Do you read differently for work than you do for pleasure? What actually changes?"

"Has skimming ever gotten you in trouble by missing something important?"

SESSION 4

Interpersonal & Networking Communication

"What's the most awkward networking conversation you've ever had, and what did you learn from it?"

"Have you ever avoided a conflict conversation that got worse the longer you waited? What finally made you address it?"

"What's different about how you talk to someone senior to you versus a peer? Is that difference genuinely necessary?"

| *"What's a question you've asked in a professional setting that you're genuinely proud of?"*

SESSION 5

Feedback, Reflection & Self-Assessment

| *"What's the most useful piece of feedback you've ever received? What made it land?"*

| *"Is it harder for you to give feedback or receive it? Why do you think that is?"*

| *"Has a mentor or teacher ever told you something about your communication style that surprised you?"*

| *"What's a specific moment of persuasion, an ad, a speech, a conversation, that actually worked on you? Why do you think it worked?"*

SESSION 6

Communication Systems & Tools

| *"Do you have any kind of system for taking notes, tracking goals, or organizing your communication? What's actually working, and what isn't?"*

| *"Have you ever used a visual, a diagram, chart, or sketch, to explain something words alone weren't landing? What happened?"*

| *"What's one communication habit you've built over the course of this program that's already changed how you show up day to day?"*

| *"If you had to set one communication goal for the next month, what would genuinely move the needle for you?"*